

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: EPA

Donald Trump said his two-hour meeting with **Xi Jinping** in Beijing was “great”. According to a White House readout, the leaders agreed that the Strait of Hormuz must be opened and Mr Xi indicated willingness to purchase more American oil. Chinese statements did not mention either topic. Earlier Mr Xi warned that any mishandling of [Taiwan](#) could plunge the relationship into “great jeopardy”, according to Chinese state media.

Wes Streeting, Britain’s health secretary, resigned, saying he has “lost confidence” in [Sir Keir Starmer](#). He is expected to launch a formal leadership challenge against the prime minister, who is facing mounting pressure to step down. Earlier **Angela Rayner**, who resigned as deputy prime minister in September after being accused of deliberately underpaying property tax, was cleared of wrongdoing, paving the way for another potential leadership bid.

America’s Senate confirmed **Kevin Warsh** as chairman of the **Federal Reserve**. The 54-45 vote was the closest since Senate approval became a requirement in 1977. Only one Democrat backed [Mr Warsh](#). Now he must deal with rising inflation: figures released on Wednesday showed the producer-price index, a

measure of wholesale inflation, climbed by 6% in the 12 months to April—the biggest increase since December 2022.

Latvia's government collapsed after **Evika Silina**, the prime minister, announced her resignation. Ms Silina, of the centre-right New Unity party, lost her parliamentary majority on Wednesday after the left-wing Progressives withdrew from her coalition. They were angry about the government's handling of issues including stray Ukrainian drones entering Latvian territory. Edgars Rinkevics, the president, is tasked with finding a new leader of government.

Cerebras Systems, a [chipmaker](#), raised \$5.5bn in an initial public offering, valuing the company at around \$40bn. The firm priced shares at \$185, well above its initial range of \$115-125, due to strong investor demand; it also increased the number of shares from 28m to 30m. The listing was America's largest of the year, underscoring investors' appetite for AI firms.

Cuba has run out of diesel and fuel oil, its energy minister said, as America's [blockade](#) continues. Havana, the capital, has suffered blackouts lasting up to 22 hours a day. In January Mr Trump signed an executive order threatening tariffs on countries that ship oil to the island. "Cuba is open to anyone that wants to sell us fuel," the minister said.

The **Vatican** threatened to excommunicate the Priestly Fraternity of Saint Pius X, a rebel Catholic group. The anti-modernist society, set up in 1970, opposes many recent Catholic doctrines and is wedded to the Latin mass. It also plans to ordain priests without papal approval. The Vatican called that "a schismatic act". If carried out, it would be the first known excommunication under [Pope Leo XIV](#).

Figure of the day: 25%, the rough proportion of Swedish students who struggle to read properly, according to the country's higher-

education minister. [Read why](#) schools in Sweden are going unplugged.



Photograph: Alamy

Donald Trump visits Xi Jinping

The leaders will conclude the first day of their summit in Beijing with a state banquet on Thursday. Away from the pomp, America's president wants [trade to be top of the agenda](#): he is hoping to secure commitments from China to buy more American beans and Boeing aircraft. Each side is uneasy about export controls imposed by the other. America wants China to keep critical minerals flowing, while China wants greater access to advanced American computer chips.

But a potential dispute over [Taiwan](#) looms. Mr Xi has been pressing America to say that it “opposes” the island's independence. And although both leaders put on a show of good humour at the summit, Mr Xi earlier warned that disagreement over Taiwan could result in “confrontation, or even conflict”. The temptation for Mr Trump to make concessions may grow.



Photograph: Getty Images

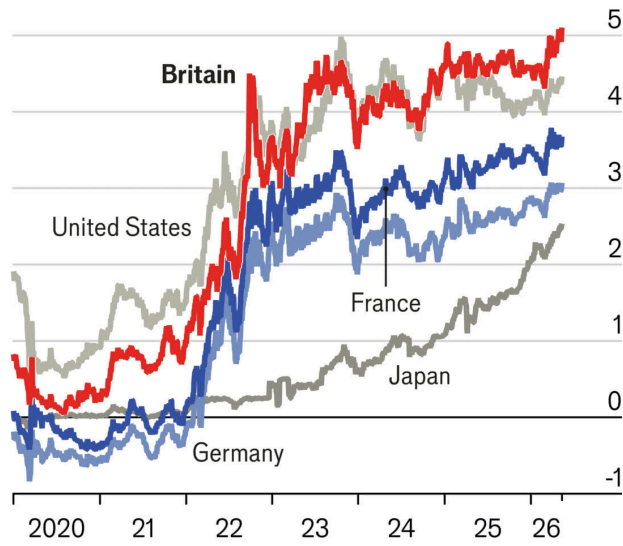
Britain's bond market bites back

Since the Iran war began yields on ten-year gilts, as British government bonds are called, have leapt from 4.2% to just over 5%. Rising energy prices are pushing up inflation—and therefore borrowing costs—everywhere. Britain is unusually vulnerable, however. It imports large amounts of energy and struggled to tame high inflation even before the crisis. Poor fiscal choices by recent governments have also led investors to demand greater compensation for holding what they see as riskier debt.

Political turmoil [continues to keep borrowing costs high](#). The prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, is a lame duck. Wes Streeting, the health secretary, is planning a leadership challenge. Some of the prime minister's other rivals have sought to dismiss the bond market, but the danger is not abstract. If current yields were pencilled into forecasts at the next budget, debt-servicing costs in 2029-30 would be roughly £7bn (\$9.5bn) more than thought in March. That is equivalent to an extra penny in every pound on income tax.

Gilty displeasure

Ten-year government-bond yields, %



Source: LSEG Workspace



Illustration: David Simonds

India plays anxious host to the BRICS

Over the next two days India will hold what promises to be a contentious BRICS meeting. Subrahmanyam Jaishankar is hosting fellow foreign ministers from the bloc of rising non-Western economies, including Russia's Sergei Lavrov and Iran's Abbas Araghchi.

India aspires to be a bridge between the West and the rest. In convening the group, it had hoped to signal its solidarity with the “global south” even as it nurtures closer ties with America and Europe. But in fact the gathering has become a diplomatic headache.

With Iran and the United Arab Emirates attending—both of whom have joined the bloc since 2024—India is likely to be drawn into debates about [the war in the Middle East](#), which it would rather avoid. Indeed, while the BRICS gathering was meant to boost the clout of countries like India, a simultaneous meeting between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping in Beijing will only highlight how middle-ranking powers are still at the mercy of the world's two greatest.



Photograph: eyevine

Squabbling over stablecoins

America's Senate Banking Committee will mull over proposed crypto-market rules on Thursday. Bankers and crypto firms have clashed over parts of the Clarity Act, particularly those relating to [stablecoins](#), cryptocurrencies pegged to the dollar.

Last year's Genius Act set the rules for American stablecoins, but the two sides disagree over a loophole which allows crypto exchanges to pass on returns, or "yields", to holders. Banks fear this will lure savers who would otherwise deposit cash with them. The new bill tightens the ways in which exchanges can pass on yields and increases mandatory checks on customers.

Wall Street is still not satisfied. The American Bankers Association, a trade group, says the rules are not strong enough. Members of the banking committee have proposed more than 100 amendments which could be discussed at the hearing before the bill advances to the Senate floor. True clarity may be some way off.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which famous physicist produced some of his most important work while employed at the Swiss patent office?

Wednesday: The departure of which baseball player in 1920 is supposed to have resulted in a long-lasting curse on the Boston Red Sox?

*The beautiful thing about learning
is nobody can take it away from
you.*

B.B. King